Let them have their education in peace.

Apparently that agreement had now expired, because there I was, splattered across the front page, made out to seem a delicate flower. Or an ass. Or both.

And knocking on death's door.

I read the article several times. Despite the somber subtext—something's very wrong with Prince Harry—I marveled at its tone: larky. My existence was just fun and games to these people. I wasn't a human being to them. I wasn't a fourteen-year-old boy hanging on by his fingernails. I was a cartoon character, a glove puppet to be manipulated and mocked for fun. So what if their fun made my already difficult days more difficult, made me a laughingstock before my schoolmates, not to mention the wider world? So what if they were torturing a child? All was justified because I was royal, and in their minds royal was synonymous with non-person. Centuries ago royal men and women were considered divine; now they were insects. What fun, to pluck their wings.

Pa's office lodged a formal complaint, publicly demanded an apology, accused the paper of bullying his younger son.

The newspaper told Pa's office to sod off.

Before trying to move on with my life I took one last look at the article. Of all the things that surprised me about it, the truly flabbergasting thing was the absolutely shitty writing. I was a poor student, a dreadful writer, and yet I had enough education to recognize that this right here was a master class in illiteracy.

To take one example: After explaining that I'd been grievously injured, that I was nearly at death's door, the article went on to caution breathlessly that the exact nature of my injury couldn't be revealed because the Royal Family had forbidden the editors to do so. (As if my family had any control over these ghouls.) "To reassure you, we can say that Harry's injuries are NOT serious. But the accident was considered grave enough for him to be taken to hospital. But we believe you are entitled to know if an heir to the throne is involved in any accident, however small, if it results in injury."

The two "buts" in a row, the smug self-regard, the lack of coherence and absence of any real point, the hysterical nothingness of it all. This dog's dinner of a paragraph was said to be edited—or, more likely, written—by a young journalist whose name I scanned and then quickly forgot.

I didn't think I'd ever run across it, or him, again. The way he wrote? I couldn't imagine he'd be a working journalist much longer.